

BRITISH UNIFORM AND KIT OF THE NAPOLEONIC WARS

The **British line and light infantry** in the Napoleonic Wars wore bright red jackets. The eye-catching colour was a sensible choice in an era when visibility during battles was often severely reduced by clouds of gunpowder smoke, making it difficult to distinguish friend from foe. Infantrymen wore the “stovepipe” shako as standard from 1801 to 1812. A soldier’s most important piece of equipment was the flintlock Land-Pattern musket known as “Brown Bess”, but he also had to carry a haversack, food bag, kettle, greatcoat, blanket, and water canteens, as well as ammunition. This represented a heavy burden on marches of up to 25km (15 miles) a day.



White straps were polished with pipe clay

Musket ball in cartridge



Powder charge

CARTRIDGES

▲ CARTRIDGE POUCH

Date c.1800

Origin UK

Material Leather

The bag could hold 60 cartridges, each of which contained powder and a musket ball. The powder was used as both primer and charge, while the paper served as wadding to keep the musket ball in the barrel.



◀ MUSKET BALLS

Date c.1800

Origin UK

Weight 32gm (1oz)

Diameter 1.7cm (2/3in)

Musket balls were made of lead. Balls were classified by their “bore”—the number of balls that could be cast from 0.45kg (1lb) of lead.



CLOSED VIEW



OPEN VIEW

White leather strap

Waterproofed canvas

Leather sling

▲ BRITISH LIGHT INFANTRY “TROTTER” KNAPSACK

Date c.1805

Origin UK

Material Wood, canvas

► GREEN-PLUMED LIGHT INFANTRY SHAKO

Date 1801

Origin UK

Material Felt, leather

The cylindrical British light-infantry shako was made of felt with a leather peak. The bugle-horn badge and green plume were symbols of light infantry.



Green plume of light infantry

Leather peak

► TUNIC

Date c.1810

Origin UK

Material Wool, linen lining

Private soldiers wore a single-breasted brick-red tunic. The green facings on the collar and cuffs and the shape, colour, and spacing of the lace were all light infantry features.

Lace colours specific to light infantry

► TROUSERS

Date c.1810

Origin UK

Material Wool

During the Peninsular War, the light infantryman’s white breeches and black gaiters gave way to the grey trousers shown here. Made of thick wool, they were stiflingly hot in summer.



▲ SHOES

Date c.1800

Origin UK

Material Leather

Shoes were issued “straight-lasted” (with neither left nor right) and were often of extremely poor quality. A soldier was issued only two pairs each year.